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Introduction & Applicability

The American Psychological Association's (APA's) Ethical Principles of Psychologists and Code of Conduct, known as the **Ethics Code**, is a document that outlines the rules and guidelines for psychologists to follow. It includes an Introduction, a Preamble (the opening or beginning part of a document), five General Principles, and specific Ethical Standards.

The Introduction provides information about the purpose, structure, and scope of the Ethics Code. The Preamble and General Principles are like goals or ideals that psychologists should strive for. While they are not strict rules that must be followed, psychologists should consider them when making ethical decisions.

The Ethical Standards, on the other hand, are enforceable rules that psychologists must adhere to. They provide specific guidelines for professional conduct. The Standards are often written broadly to apply to psychologists in different roles, but their application may vary depending on the situation.

It's important to note that the Ethical Standards don't cover every possible situation. Just because a specific behavior or action is not mentioned in the Standards doesn't automatically make it ethical or unethical. Psychologists must use their judgment and consider the broader principles and values outlined in the Ethics Code when facing new or uncertain ethical dilemmas.

This set of rules, called the **Ethics Code**, only applies to psychologists when they are doing their jobs as scientists, educators, or professionals in psychology. It covers many different things they do, like helping people in therapy, doing research, teaching, supervising students, working for the community, creating tests, giving advice in education, helping organizations, working on legal cases, planning and evaluating programs, and doing administrative tasks.

These rules apply to all these activities, whether they happen in person, through mail, phone calls, online, or other electronic ways. But it's important to know that the Ethics Code doesn't

control how psychologists behave in their personal lives. It only focuses on how they act when they're working as professionals.

When someone becomes a member or student affiliate of the APA (American Psychological Association), they agree to follow the rules in the APA Ethics Code and the processes that are used to enforce those rules. It's important to understand that not knowing or misunderstanding an Ethical Standard is not an excuse if someone is accused of acting unethically. In other words, simply claiming that you didn't know the rule or didn't understand it won't protect you from facing consequences if you're found to have behaved unethically.

The processes for reporting, looking into, and solving complaints about unethical behavior are explained in the current Rules and Procedures of the APA Ethics Committee. If a member of the APA breaks the rules in the Ethics Code, the APA can take actions like ending their membership and informing others about what they did. Even if someone is not an APA member, if they do something that goes against the Ethics Code, they can face consequences from other organizations or agencies like state psychological associations, professional groups, psychology boards, government agencies, or insurance companies that pay for health services.

Furthermore, the APA has the authority to take action against a member in certain situations. These include if the member is found guilty of a serious crime, if they are expelled or suspended from a state psychological association, or if their license to practice is suspended or revoked. When the APA decides on a punishment that is less severe than expulsion, the rules and procedures from 2001 do not guarantee the member a chance to speak in person during the process. Instead, the complaints are usually resolved based on the information provided in written records.

The purpose of the Ethics Code is to give psychologists guidance and rules for how they should behave professionally. It can be used by the APA and other organizations that decide to follow it. However, it's important to note that the Ethics Code is not meant to be the sole basis for legal responsibility. Just because a psychologist breaks the rules in the Ethics Code doesn't automatically mean they will be held legally liable in a court, that a contract they have is enforceable, or that other legal consequences will definitely happen. The Ethics Code and legal matters are separate and can be handled differently.

Certain words like "reasonably," "appropriate," and "potentially" are included in some of the standards of this Ethics Code. These words serve a purpose:

1. They allow psychologists to use their professional judgment when deciding how to apply the standards.
2. They prevent unfairness or inequality that could occur without these modifiers.
3. They make sure the standards apply to a wide range of activities that psychologists engage in.
4. They prevent the establishment of strict and inflexible rules that could become outdated quickly.

In this Ethics Code, the term "reasonable" means that psychologists should make judgments based on what other professionals in similar activities and circumstances would consider reasonable. It takes into account the knowledge the psychologist had or should have had at the time.

Certainly! Let's consider a hypothetical example to illustrate the points in the paragraph:

Imagine a psychologist is working with a client who is experiencing depression. One of the ethical standards in the Ethics Code states that psychologists should use appropriate treatment interventions. In this case, the use of the word "appropriate" allows the psychologist to make a professional judgment based on their expertise and the specific needs of the client. It recognizes that different clients may require different approaches or therapies.

Furthermore, the term "reasonable" comes into play when determining what treatment approach to use. The prevailing professional judgment of psychologists engaged in similar activities in similar circumstances would guide the psychologist's decision-making. They would consider what other professionals with similar expertise would deem reasonable in treating a client with depression, given the knowledge they possess or should possess.

These modifiers in the Ethics Code enable psychologists to exercise professional judgment, ensure fairness and adaptability, and promote the application of standards across diverse psychological situations.

When psychologists make decisions about how they should behave professionally, they need to think about not only the Ethics Code but also the laws and regulations set by psychology boards. They can also consider other guidelines endorsed by scientific and professional psychological organizations and listen to their own conscience. It's important for psychologists to follow the Ethics Code even if it requires a higher standard of behavior than what the law demands. If

there's a conflict between a psychologist's ethical responsibilities and the law or regulations, they should let others know that they are committed to the Ethics Code. They should then take steps to resolve the conflict in a responsible way that respects basic human rights.

PREAMBLE (brief introduction)

Psychologists have a strong commitment to advancing our knowledge of human behavior and helping people understand themselves and others. They use this knowledge to make improvements in individuals, organizations, and society as a whole. Psychologists value and protect civil and human rights, recognizing the importance of freedom of inquiry and expression in their research, teaching, and publications. They aim to assist the public in making well-informed judgments and choices about human behavior. Psychologists fulfill various roles, such as researchers, educators, diagnosticians, therapists, supervisors, consultants, administrators, social interventionists, and expert witnesses. The Ethics Code serves as a shared set of principles and standards that psychologists use as a foundation for their professional and scientific work.

The purpose of the Ethics Code is to give psychologists clear guidelines for how to behave in various situations they may encounter. Its main goals are to ensure the well-being and protection of the people psychologists work with, and to educate psychologists, students, and the public about the ethical standards of the field.

Creating a set of ethical standards that guides psychologists in how they behave professionally is an ongoing process. It requires psychologists to personally commit to acting ethically and continuously strive to do so throughout their careers. They also have a responsibility to promote ethical behavior among students, supervisees, employees, and colleagues. Whenever they face ethical challenges, psychologists should seek advice and guidance from others in order to make the best ethical decisions.

General Principles

In this section, we have General Principles. These principles are different from Ethical Standards because they are meant to inspire and guide psychologists towards the best ethical ideals of the profession. Unlike Ethical Standards, General Principles are not strict obligations and should not be used to punish or impose penalties. Using General Principles for these purposes would misunderstand their true meaning and purpose.

Principle A: Beneficence (To benefit others) **and Nonmaleficence** (Avoiding Harm)

psychologists work to help and benefit the people they interact with while making sure not to cause any harm. They take steps to protect the well-being and rights of those they work with, as well as other individuals affected by their actions. This includes considering the welfare of

animals involved in research. When psychologists face conflicts between their responsibilities or concerns, they try to find a responsible solution that prevents or reduces harm. Since the decisions and actions of psychologists can impact the lives of others, they are careful to watch out for personal, financial, social, organizational, or political factors that could lead to the misuse of their influence. Psychologists also strive to be aware of how their own physical and mental health can affect their ability to help those they work with.

Here's an example to understand Principle A: Beneficence and Nonmaleficence:

Let's imagine a psychologist working in a school. Their goal is to benefit the students they work with and ensure their well-being. They strive to create a safe and supportive environment for the students, where their rights are respected. The psychologist takes care to do no harm and avoids actions that could potentially hurt the students emotionally or psychologically.

In their professional role, the psychologist may encounter conflicts. For example, there may be a situation where a student's right to privacy conflicts with their safety. In such cases, the psychologist will responsibly navigate the situation, finding a balance between protecting the student's privacy and ensuring their safety.

Additionally, the psychologist remains aware of any personal biases or external influences that could impact their judgment. They understand that personal, financial, or social factors should not interfere with their ability to provide objective and unbiased support to the students.

The psychologist also takes care of their own physical and mental well-being. They understand that if they are experiencing personal difficulties or stress, it may affect their ability to effectively help the students. Therefore, they prioritize self-care and seek support when needed, ensuring they are in the best state to assist those they work with.

Principle B: Fidelity (Being Trustworthy) and Responsibility (Being Responsible)

Psychologists build relationships based on trust with the people they work with. They understand their responsibilities as professionals and scientists, both to society as a whole and to the specific communities they serve. Psychologists follow professional standards of behavior, clearly define their roles and obligations, take appropriate responsibility for their actions, and work to resolve conflicts of interest that could potentially harm or exploit others.

Psychologists also collaborate and seek advice from other professionals and institutions when necessary to ensure the best interests of the people they work with. They are concerned about their colleagues' ethical conduct in both scientific research and professional practice.

In addition, psychologists are committed to contributing a portion of their professional time to help others, even without expecting much **compensation** or personal gain. They understand the importance of giving back to their **communities** and **using their** expertise for the benefit of others.

Here's another example to help students understand Principle B: Fidelity and Responsibility:

Imagine a psychologist who works in a school setting. Their main goal is to help students with their emotional well-being and academic success. To build trust, the psychologist listens to the students without judgment, respects their confidentiality, and keeps their personal information private.

The psychologist understands their responsibility to the school community and follows professional guidelines. They attend regular meetings to discuss students' progress, collaborate with teachers and parents, and provide valuable insights to support the students' development.

If a conflict of interest arises, such as having a close relationship with a student's family, the psychologist takes appropriate steps to manage the situation. They might inform the school administration, seek guidance from their supervisor, or transfer the case to another psychologist to ensure unbiased and fair treatment.

Additionally, the psychologist recognizes the importance of working alongside other professionals. They consult with teachers, school counselors, and administrators to better understand the students' needs and provide comprehensive support. By collaborating with others, they ensure that the students receive the best possible care and guidance.

Moreover, the psychologist believes in giving back to the community. They volunteer their time to conduct workshops on mental health awareness, offer free counseling sessions to students in need, or provide guidance to teachers on supporting students' emotional well-being.

Through their fidelity and responsibility, the psychologist establishes trust, upholds professional standards, collaborates with others, and contributes to the overall well-being of the students and the school community.

Principle C: Integrity

Psychologists believe in being honest, truthful, and accurate in their work as scientists, educators, and practitioners of psychology. They never steal, cheat, commit fraud, deceive others, or intentionally misrepresent facts.

Psychologists make sure to keep their promises and avoid making unwise or unclear commitments. They understand the importance of being reliable and trustworthy in their professional relationships.

However, there may be situations where using deception is necessary to achieve certain benefits or minimize harm. In such cases, psychologists have a serious responsibility. They carefully consider the need for deception, the potential consequences, and their duty to address any mistrust or harm that may arise from it. If deception is used, they are committed to correcting any negative effects and rebuilding trust with those involved.

Example

Imagine a psychologist conducting a research study on children's behavior. They want to observe how children interact with each other in a natural setting. To get accurate results, the psychologist needs to blend in and not draw attention to themselves. So, they decide to dress and act like a regular person in the environment without revealing their true identity as a researcher. This allows them to observe the children's behavior without any biases or changes in their actions.

In this example, the psychologist is using deception by not disclosing their true purpose. However, they have a responsibility to ensure that this deception does not cause any harm or mistrust among the children or their parents. If any negative effects arise from the deception, the psychologist will take steps to address them and rebuild trust in a responsible manner. This demonstrates the principle of integrity, where honesty and accuracy are upheld, and any use of deception is carefully considered and managed ethically.

Principle D: Justice

Psychologists understand the importance of fairness and treating everyone equally. They believe that everyone should have the opportunity to benefit from the knowledge and help provided by psychology, and receive the same level of quality in the services and processes carried out by psychologists.

To ensure fairness, psychologists use their best judgment and take precautions to prevent any biases they may have from influencing their work. They also recognize the limits of their expertise and competence, making sure not to engage in or support unjust practices

In summary, psychologists strive to create a just and equal environment where everyone has access to psychological resources and receives fair treatment, regardless of any biases or limitations that may exist.

Example

Imagine a psychologist working in a school. They understand that fairness and justice mean that all students should have equal access to educational resources and support. To ensure this, the psychologist carefully considers their own biases and limitations. They take necessary precautions to avoid any unjust practices that could hinder a student's progress or unfairly favor certain individuals. The psychologist makes sure to provide equal opportunities for all students, regardless of their background or circumstances. They strive to create an inclusive and equitable environment where every student can thrive and receive the assistance they need.

Principle E: Respect for People's Rights and Dignity

Psychologists' value and honor the worth and importance of every person. They recognize that individuals have the right to privacy, confidentiality, and the freedom to make their own choices. Psychologists understand that certain individuals or communities may require extra protection to ensure their rights and well-being, especially when their ability to make decisions independently is affected.

Psychologists also acknowledge and respect the differences in culture, identity, age, gender, race, ethnicity, religion, sexual orientation, disability, language, and socioeconomic status. They consider these factors when working with people from diverse backgrounds. Psychologists make a conscious effort to prevent their own biases from influencing their work, and they refuse to support or engage in activities that are based on such prejudices.

In summary, psychologists show respect for all individuals by upholding their rights, treating them with dignity, and considering their unique backgrounds and circumstances. They strive to

eliminate any biases that may interfere with their work and actively promote fairness and equality.

Here's an easy and short example to illustrate Principle E: Respect for People's Rights and Dignity.

Let's say a psychologist is working with a client who is seeking therapy. The psychologist understands the importance of respecting the client's rights and dignity. They ensure that the client's personal information is kept confidential and protected. The psychologist acknowledges the client's right to privacy, allowing them to share their thoughts and feelings without fear of judgment or disclosure to others. They also respect the client's right to make their own decisions about their therapy, giving them the freedom to choose the treatment options that align with their values and preferences. Throughout the therapeutic process, the psychologist demonstrates respect for the client's individuality, cultural background, and any other factors that may influence their experiences. They actively work to eliminate any biases or prejudices that could affect the client's well-being and provide a safe and inclusive space for their growth and healing.



Ethical Standards

1. Resolving Ethical Issues

1.01 Misuse of Psychologists' Work

If psychologists become aware that their work is being misused or misrepresented, they take appropriate actions to fix or reduce the impact of this misuse or misrepresentation.

EXAMPLE

Imagine a psychologist who develops a relaxation technique called "Mindful Breathing" to help people manage stress. They later discover that a self-proclaimed "expert" is teaching Mindful Breathing incorrectly, potentially causing harm to individuals who follow their guidance.

In response, the psychologist takes immediate action. They reach out to the person teaching incorrectly, providing accurate information about the proper technique and its potential benefits. They also offer resources and guidance to help the person understand and teach Mindful Breathing effectively.

By doing so, the psychologist takes reasonable steps to correct the misuse of their work and ensure that individuals receive accurate and safe guidance in practicing Mindful Breathing.

1.02 Conflicts between Ethics and Law, Regulations, or Other Governing Legal Authority

If psychologists face a situation where their ethical duties clash with the law or other rules, they must understand the conflict. They make it clear that they are dedicated to following the Ethics Code, which guides their professional conduct. They then take appropriate actions to resolve the

conflict in a way that aligns with the overall principles and standards of the Ethics Code. It's important to note that this standard should never be used as an excuse to violate human rights.

Certainly! Here's a short, simple example:

Imagine a psychologist working in a school setting who learns that a student is being bullied by their classmates. The psychologist strongly believes in maintaining the privacy and well-being of students, which is an ethical responsibility. However, the school's rules state that any incidents of bullying must be reported to the principal and addressed according to disciplinary procedures.

In this situation, the psychologist faces a conflict between their ethical duty to protect the student's privacy and the legal requirement to report bullying incidents. To navigate this conflict, the psychologist would first acknowledge the nature of the conflict and recognize their commitment to the Ethics Code. They would then take reasonable steps to find a resolution that respects both the student's rights and the legal obligations, such as consulting with the principal and finding ways to address the bullying while preserving the student's privacy.

It's important to emphasize that regardless of the conflict, the psychologist should never use this standard to justify or defend actions that violate the fundamental human rights of any individual involved.

1.03 Conflicts Between Ethics and Organizational Demands

If psychologists find themselves in a situation where the requirements of the organization they work for or are affiliated with clash with the Ethics Code, they need to understand the nature of the conflict. They should communicate their dedication to the Ethics Code and take reasonable actions to resolve the conflict in a way that aligns with the principles and standards of the Ethics Code. However, it's crucial to note that this standard can never be used as an excuse to violate the fundamental human rights of individuals.

EXAMPLE:

Suppose a psychologist is employed by a large corporation and is asked by their superiors to manipulate research findings to favor the company's interests, even if it compromises the integrity of the study. However, the psychologist recognizes that their ethical responsibility is to conduct research with honesty and accuracy. In this situation, the psychologist would address the conflict by communicating the nature of the conflict to their superiors, expressing their commitment to the Ethics Code, and taking reasonable steps to resolve the conflict while upholding the principles and standards outlined in the Ethics Code. They would not use this standard as a justification to violate human rights or compromise the integrity of their work.

1.04 Informal Resolution of Ethical Violations

When psychologists think that another psychologist may have acted unethically, they try to address the issue by discussing it with that person. If the situation allows for a casual conversation and it doesn't breach any confidentiality rights, they attempt to find a solution together. This approach is applicable when there is no conflict between ethical principles and laws, regulations, or organizational requirements. (Also see Standards 1.02, Conflicts Between Ethics and Law, Regulations, or Other Governing Legal Authority, and 1.03, Conflicts Between Ethics and Organizational Demands.)

EXAMPLE

Imagine a situation where two psychologists work in the same clinic. One psychologist notices that the other psychologist is sharing confidential patient information with unauthorized individuals. The concerned psychologist decides to talk privately with their colleague and address the issue. They explain the importance of maintaining confidentiality and discuss how the actions may be unethical. Together, they work towards finding a solution and ensuring that patient rights and confidentiality are respected.

1.05 Reporting Ethical Violations

If a psychologist becomes aware of a serious ethical violation that has caused or is likely to cause significant harm to a person or organization, and the issue cannot be resolved informally, they must take appropriate action. This may involve reporting the violation to state or national committees on professional ethics, state licensing boards, or the relevant authorities within their institution. However, this standard does not apply if taking action would violate confidentiality rights or if the psychologist has been specifically hired to review the work of another psychologist whose conduct is being questioned.

EXAMPLE

Mark, a psychologist working in a school, becomes aware that one of his colleagues has been engaging in inappropriate relationships with students, which is a clear violation of ethical standards. This misconduct has the potential to cause significant harm to the students involved and compromise the integrity of the educational environment.

Action: Mark recognizes the seriousness of the situation and decides to take further action to address the ethical violation. He immediately reports the misconduct to the school administration and provides them with all the relevant information and evidence he has gathered. Mark understands the importance of protecting the well-being and rights of the students, and he takes steps to ensure that appropriate measures are taken to address the situation, such as involving the school board or relevant authorities if necessary.

1.06 Cooperating with Ethics Committees

Psychologists work together and help with ethics investigations and procedures conducted by the APA or their state psychological association. They also follow any rules about keeping things private and confidential. It's considered wrong if psychologists refuse to cooperate in these investigations. However, if they ask for a delay in resolving an ethics complaint until a legal case is finished, that request alone is not seen as refusing to cooperate.

EXAMPLE

Imagine there is a psychologist named Dr. Johnson who is a member of their state psychological association. One day, the association receives a complaint against Dr. Johnson, accusing them of breaching ethical guidelines in their practice. The association decides to conduct an ethics investigation to gather more information and determine the validity of the complaint.

In this situation, Dr. Johnson fully cooperates with the ethics investigation. They provide all the necessary documents, records, and information requested by the association. Dr. Johnson also attends meetings and interviews with the investigating committee, openly discussing the allegations and answering any questions.

By actively cooperating with the ethics investigation, Dr. Johnson demonstrates their willingness to address the complaint and engage in a fair and transparent process. They recognize the importance of the investigation in upholding professional ethics and maintaining the trust and integrity of the psychology profession

1.07 Improper Complaints

Psychologists should not make or support ethics complaints that are filed without proper consideration of the facts or with the intention of ignoring evidence that would prove the accusation false.

EXAMPLE

Imagine a situation where a psychologist hears a colleague spreading false rumors about another psychologist, claiming that they acted unethically. However, the psychologist knows that these rumors are based on unfounded assumptions and have no supporting evidence. In this case, the psychologist should avoid or abstain from encouraging or participating in filing an ethics

complaint against the accused colleague because it would be unfair and irresponsible to make such a complaint without considering the facts or intentionally disregarding evidence that could disprove the allegations.

Unfair Discrimination Against Complainants and Respondents

Psychologists should not reject or discriminate against individuals in terms of employment, career advancement, admission to academic programs, tenure, or promotion solely because they have made an ethics complaint or because they are the subject of such a complaint. However, this doesn't mean that the outcome of the ethics proceedings or other relevant information cannot be taken into account when making decisions or taking appropriate actions.

EXAMPLE

Imagine a scenario where a psychologist is responsible for reviewing applications for a prestigious academic program. One of the applicants has been the subject of an ethics complaint in the past. The psychologist must not reject the applicant's admission solely based on their previous involvement in an ethics complaint. They should evaluate the applicant's qualifications, skills, and suitability for the program based on fair and unbiased criteria, taking into account the outcome of the ethics complaint and any other relevant information.

2. Competence (refers to the knowledge, skills, abilities, and expertise that a psychologist possesses in their professional field.)

2.01 Boundaries of Competence

(a) Psychologists only provide services, teach, and conduct research in areas that they are qualified and experienced in. This is based on their education, training, supervised experience, consultation, study, or professional experience.

EXAMPLE

A psychologist who specializes in child psychology would provide counseling and therapy services to children and their families, as well as conduct research on child development. They would not offer services in areas such as forensic psychology, as these are outside their area of expertise.

(b) If knowledge about specific factors like age, gender, race, ethnicity, culture, religion, sexual orientation, disability, language, or socioeconomic status is necessary for psychologists to effectively help their clients or conduct research, they acquire the necessary training, experience,

consultation, or supervision. If they lack competence in a particular area, they make appropriate referrals, unless it's an emergency situation.

EXAMPLE

Let's say there's a psychologist who specializes in cognitive-behavioral therapy (CBT) for anxiety disorders. They have completed extensive training and have a wealth of experience in helping clients with anxiety. Now, imagine a person comes to them seeking treatment for an eating disorder. While the psychologist understands the importance of addressing eating disorders, it's not their area of expertise. In this case, they refer the person to a colleague who specializes in eating disorder treatment. By doing this, the psychologist ensures that the individual receives the most effective and appropriate care from a specialist who has specific knowledge and skills in treating eating disorders.

(c) When psychologists plan to work with new populations, areas, techniques, or technologies, they undergo relevant education, training, supervised experience, consultation, or study to ensure they are competent.

EXAMPLE

Imagine a psychologist who has been primarily helping individuals struggling with anxiety and stress decides to expand their practice to include couples therapy. To ensure they are competent in this new area, the psychologist takes part in workshops, receives supervision from experienced couples therapists, and familiarizes themselves with effective strategies and techniques for relationship counseling. This additional training equips them with the necessary skills to provide valuable support and guidance to couples seeking help with their relationships.

(d) If mental health services are unavailable for individuals and psychologists lack the required competence, psychologists with closely related training or experience may provide services, but they must make a reasonable effort to obtain the necessary competence through research, training, consultation, or study.

EXAMPLE

Suppose a small rural community lacks mental health services for children and adolescents. A psychologist who specializes in working with adults but has some knowledge and experience with child psychology may step in to provide support to the young population. While they may not have extensive training specifically in child psychology, they make a genuine effort to

enhance their competence in this area by attending relevant workshops, consulting with child psychologists, and studying evidence-based practices for working with children. This ensures that the community's children receive the support they need, despite the limited availability of specialized services.

(e) In emerging areas where specific training standards are not yet established, psychologists still take reasonable steps to ensure their competence and protect the well-being of their clients, students, research participants, organizational clients, and others from harm.

EXAMPLE

Imagine a psychologist who typically conducts research on cognitive development in children. However, they are presented with an opportunity to conduct research on the effects of technology on memory in older adults. Recognizing that this is a new area for them, the psychologist takes the necessary steps to acquire relevant education and training on studying the effects of technology on memory in older adults. By doing so, they ensure their competence in the new area before conducting the research and strive to protect the well-being of the research participants.

(f) When psychologists take on forensic roles, they make sure to learn and understand the rules and regulations that govern their responsibilities in the legal or administrative systems. This helps them fulfill their roles effectively and responsibly.

EXAMPLE

Imagine a psychologist who is asked to testify as an expert witness in a court trial. Before taking on this forensic role, the psychologist takes the time to familiarize themselves with the rules and procedures of the judicial system. They learn about the expectations and requirements of their role in order to provide accurate and reliable information to the court. This ensures that the psychologist can effectively contribute to the legal proceedings and fulfill their responsibilities in a knowledgeable and responsible manner.

2.02 Providing Services in Emergencies

provide help to individuals even if they don't have specific training in that area. This is done to make sure that people in need don't go without assistance. However, once the emergency is over or when suitable services become available, psychologists stop providing those services and refer the individuals to the appropriate professionals.

EXAMPLE

During a natural disaster, such as a major earthquake, mental health services may become scarce or inaccessible. In such emergencies, psychologists who specialize in trauma therapy but have not received training in disaster response may still offer support and counseling to affected individuals. Their goal is to ensure that people receive the necessary help during the crisis. Once the situation stabilizes and regular mental health services are restored, the psychologists will step back and refer the individuals to experts who have specific training in disaster recovery and resilience.

2.03 Maintaining Competence

Psychologists continuously work to improve and keep their skills up-to-date.

2.04 Bases for Scientific and Professional Judgments

Psychologists rely on well-established scientific and professional knowledge in their work. They make informed decisions based on this knowledge to ensure effective and ethical practice.

Example

when diagnosing a patient with depression, psychologists rely on research-backed criteria and treatment approaches that have been shown to be effective in addressing depressive symptoms. They do not rely on personal opinions or unsupported beliefs when making professional judgments.

2.05 Delegation of Work to Others

Psychologists who assign tasks to employees, assistants, or other individuals, or who seek assistance from others like interpreters, take appropriate measures to ensure that:

1. They do not assign work to individuals who have a personal relationship with the people they are serving, which could lead to exploitation or biased judgments.
2. They authorize only those responsibilities that the assigned individuals are qualified to perform based on their education, training, or experience, either independently or under appropriate supervision.
3. They ensure that the assigned individuals perform their tasks competently. It is important to refer to other relevant standards such as Providing Services in Emergencies, Multiple Relationships, Maintaining Confidentiality, Bases for Assessments, Use of Assessments, Informed Consent in Assessments, and Assessment by Unqualified Persons.

Example

For example, let's say a psychologist has a busy practice and needs assistance with administrative tasks. They hire an administrative assistant to help with scheduling appointments, managing

paperwork, and handling phone calls. To ensure appropriate delegation of work, the psychologist:

1. Ensures that the administrative assistant does not have a personal relationship with the clients, so there is no potential for exploitation or biased treatment.
2. Assigns tasks to the assistant that they are qualified to handle based on their training and experience. This may include providing them with necessary instructions or guidance.
3. Monitors the assistant's performance to ensure that they are performing their duties competently and meeting the required standards.

By following these guidelines, the psychologist ensures that the work delegated to others is carried out responsibly and effectively.

2.06 Personal Problems and Conflicts

1. Psychologists avoid starting a task or activity if they are aware or should be aware that their personal problems will likely prevent them from doing their work well.
2. If psychologists become aware of personal problems that might affect their ability to perform their job effectively, they take the necessary steps to address the issue. This may include seeking professional advice or help and deciding whether they need to reduce, pause, or stop their work duties. (See also Standard 10.10, Ending Therapy.)

In simple terms, psychologists avoid taking on tasks if their personal problems might get in the way of doing a good job. And if they realize that personal problems are affecting their work, they seek help and decide how to handle their job responsibilities appropriately.

3. Human Relations

3.01 Unfair Discrimination

Psychologists do not treat people unfairly at work because of things like age, gender, race, culture, religion, or disabilities. They follow the laws that say they can't discriminate against someone based on these things.

3.02 Sexual Harassment

Psychologists Do Not Engage in Sexual Harassment:

Psychologists are professionals who do not participate in sexual harassment. Sexual harassment refers to unwelcome sexual advances, requests for sexual favors, or any sexual behavior, whether expressed verbally or non-verbally. It includes actions that occur in the psychologist's professional role and can create a hostile or offensive environment. Psychologists are aware that such behavior is unacceptable.

Definition of Sexual Harassment:

Sexual harassment can be a single severe incident or a series of persistent acts. It involves behaviors that are sexual in nature and can be physical or verbal. These actions occur within the psychologist's professional activities and roles. There are two main types of sexual harassment:

1. Unwelcome and Offensive:

Sexual harassment occurs when advances or conduct are unwanted, offensive, and create a hostile environment for work or education. Psychologists should be aware that such behavior is not acceptable, whether they themselves perceive it as offensive or if someone informs them about it.

2. Severe or Intense Abuse:

Sexual harassment can also be categorized as severe or intense, causing significant harm to a reasonable person in the given context. This refers to acts that are particularly severe, intense, or abusive in nature.

It is essential to refer to Standard 1.08, which addresses unfair discrimination against complainants and respondents in cases of sexual harassment.

Overall, psychologists are committed to maintaining a safe and respectful environment, free from sexual harassment, within their professional activities and roles.

3.03 Other Harassment

Title: Psychologists and Respectful Behavior

Psychologists Treat Everyone with Respect:

Psychologists are professionals who make sure to treat everyone they interact with at work respectfully. They do not knowingly engage in any behavior that harasses or demeans others. They understand that people should be treated well, regardless of their age, gender, race, culture, religion, disability, or other factors.

Respecting Differences:

Psychologists value and respect the differences that exist among people. They do not mistreat or demean others based on factors like age, gender, gender identity, race, ethnicity, culture, national origin, religion, sexual orientation, disability, language, or how much money they have.

Maintaining a Positive Work Environment

Psychologists are committed to creating a positive and inclusive work environment. They understand that it is important to treat everyone with kindness and fairness, regardless of their personal characteristics or backgrounds.

In summary, psychologists make sure to treat everyone they work with respectfully and avoid any behavior that may harass or belittle others. They value diversity and strive to maintain a positive work environment where everyone feels respected and included.

3.04 Avoiding Harm

Psychologists Keep People Safe:

(A) Psychologists do their best to make sure they don't harm the people they work with, such as clients/patients, students, research participants, and others. They take reasonable steps to prevent harm and minimize it when it's expected and cannot be avoided.

Prioritizing Safety:

The safety and well-being of the people psychologists work with are important. Psychologists take precautions to avoid causing harm to others. They also try to minimize any harm that might happen in situations where it is expected and cannot be prevented.

(B) Psychologists do not take part in torture or support it in any way. Torture refers to intentionally causing severe physical or mental pain or suffering to someone. They also avoid any other cruel, inhumane, or degrading behaviors that go against the rules.

Example

Let's say there is a psychologist named Dr. Smith who works in a prison. One day, a prison guard approaches Dr. Smith and asks for assistance in torturing a prisoner. However, Dr. Smith firmly refuses to participate or support any form of torture. Instead, Dr. Smith focuses on providing ethical and compassionate care to the prisoners, ensuring their well-being and respecting their rights. This example shows how psychologists uphold their professional standards by not engaging in or facilitating any acts of torture or any other cruel, inhumane, or degrading behaviors.

3.05 Multiple Relationships

A multiple relationship happens when a psychologist is in two different roles with the same person at the same time, or when they are in a relationship with someone who is closely connected or related to the person they have a professional relationship with. It also includes situations where the psychologist promises to have a different relationship in the future with the person or someone closely connected to them.

A psychologist avoids getting involved in multiple relationships if those relationships could make it hard for them to be fair, skilled, or effective in their work, or if they might harm or take advantage of the person they have a professional relationship with. However, if a multiple relationship wouldn't affect their ability to do their job well or cause harm, then it's not considered unethical.

(B) If a psychologist realizes that an unexpected multiple relationship that could be harmful has occurred, they will do their best to handle the situation in a way that protects the well-being of the person involved and follows the Ethics Code. They will take reasonable actions to resolve the issue, considering what is best for the affected person and making sure to comply with ethical guidelines as much as possible.

(C) When psychologists are asked to take on multiple roles in legal or administrative proceedings due to laws, institutional policies, or exceptional situations, they make sure to clearly establish the expectations of each role and the level of confidentiality involved. They continue to clarify these expectations and any changes that may arise as the proceedings progress. This ensures that everyone involved understands their roles and responsibilities. It is also important to refer to Standards 3.04 (Avoiding Harm) and 3.07 (Third-Party Requests for Services) for additional guidance in these situations.

3.06 Conflict of Interest

Psychologists avoid getting involved in professional roles when their personal, scientific, professional, legal, financial, or other interests or relationships could reasonably make it difficult for them to be fair, skilled, or effective in their work as psychologists. They also avoid situations that might harm or take advantage of the person or organization they have a professional relationship with.

3.07 Third-Party Requests for Services

When psychologists agree to provide services to someone or a group on behalf of someone else, they try to make things clear from the beginning. They want to understand the relationship with all the people or organizations involved. This includes explaining the psychologist's role (like being a therapist, consultant, diagnostician, or expert witness), identifying who the client is, discussing how the services or information will be used, and acknowledging that there may be limits to keeping things confidential. It's important to refer to Standards 3.05 (Multiple relationships) and 4.02 (Discussing the Limits of Confidentiality) for more guidance in these situations.

3.08 Exploitative Relationships

Psychologists must not take advantage of the people they have authority over, such as clients/patients, students, supervisees, research participants, and employees. This means they

should not exploit their power or use it to benefit themselves unfairly. It's important to refer to other related standards for additional guidance, such as Standards 3.05 (Multiple Relationships), 6.04 (Fees and Financial Arrangements), 6.05 (Barter with Clients/Patients), 7.07 (Sexual Relationships with Students and Supervisees), and various standards related to sexual intimacies with clients/patients and former clients/patients.

3.09 Cooperation with Other Professionals

When it's necessary and suitable, psychologists work together with other professionals to provide the best care for their clients/patients. They collaborate and share information to ensure that clients/patients receive effective and appropriate services. It's important to also refer to Standard 4.05 (Disclosures) for additional guidance in sharing relevant information.

3.10 Informed Consent

(A) When psychologists do research or provide services like assessments, therapy, counseling, or consulting, whether in person or through electronic means, they must get the informed consent of the individuals involved. They use language that the person or people can reasonably understand. However, there may be situations where consent is not required by law or regulations, or where exceptions are specified in the Ethics Code. It's important to also refer to Standards 8.02 (Informed Consent to Research), 9.03 (Informed Consent in Assessments), and 10.01 (Informed Consent to Therapy) for more details on obtaining informed consent.

(B) When dealing with individuals who are not able to give informed consent due to legal reasons, psychologists still take steps to ensure their well-being. They provide an explanation that is appropriate for their understanding, seek their agreement or assent, consider their preferences and best interests, and obtain permission from a legally authorized person if it is allowed or necessary by law. If consent from a legally authorized person is not allowed or required by law, psychologists make sure to protect the rights and welfare of the individual in reasonable ways

(C) When someone is required by a court or another authority to receive psychological services, psychologists make sure to explain to the individual what kind of services they can expect. This includes informing them if the services are ordered by the court or mandated by another authority. Psychologists also discuss any limits to confidentiality before they begin providing the services.

(D) Psychologists make sure to keep a proper record of when individuals give their consent, whether it's in writing or verbally. They also document when individuals give permission or agree to participate in certain activities. It's important to refer to Standards 8.02, 9.03, and 10.01 for more guidance on documenting consent for research, assessments, and therapy.

3.11 Psychological Services Delivered to or Through Organizations

Psychologists who provide services through organizations make sure to give information to clients and those directly affected by the services before they begin. This information includes:

1. Explaining the nature and goals of the services.
2. Clarifying who the services are intended for.
3. Identifying which individuals are considered clients.
4. Describing the psychologist's relationship with each person and the organization.
5. Explaining how the services will be used and what information will be collected.
6. Clarifying who will have access to the information.
7. Discussing the limits of confidentiality.

As soon as possible, psychologists also provide relevant information about the results and conclusions of the services to the appropriate individuals.

If psychologists are legally prohibited or restricted from sharing certain information with specific individuals or groups, they inform them about this limitation right from the beginning of the service.

If psychologists are not allowed to share certain information with specific individuals or groups due to legal reasons or organizational rules, they make sure to inform those individuals or groups about this restriction at the beginning of the service.

3.12 Interruption of Psychological Services

Unless there is a specific agreement in place, psychologists make sure to take reasonable steps to plan ahead in case there is an interruption in the provision of psychological services. This can happen due to factors such as the psychologist becoming ill, passing away, being unavailable, moving to a different location, or retiring. It can also occur if the client or patient moves to a new location or faces financial limitations. Planning for these situations helps ensure that appropriate arrangements can be made. Refer to Standard 6.02c (Maintenance, Dissemination, and Disposal of Confidential Records of Professional and Scientific Work) for further guidance on handling confidential records.